Gastroenterology Service Line Handbook

MERIDIAN HEALTH PARTNERS
OPERATIONS POLICY & PROCEDURE MANUAL
SECTION 4: SERVICE LINE HANDBOOK – GASTROENTEROLOGY
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Applies To: All Gastroenterology Clinic Staff, Scheduling Coordinators, and Billing Specialists across all 14 Meridian sites.

4.1 Purpose and Scope This document establishes operational standards, clinical inclusion criteria, scheduling parameters, and insurance coverage matrices for the Gastroenterology Service Line at Meridian Health Partners. Compliance with these operational clauses is mandatory for all clinic personnel.

4.2 Conditions Accepted and Explicitly Not Accepted

4.2.1 Accepted Conditions

The Gastroenterology service line accepts ambulatory adult patients (aged 18 and older) presenting with the following confirmed or suspected primary conditions:

1. Chronic gastroesophageal reflux disease (GERD) refractory to primary care management.
2. Inflammatory Bowel Disease (IBD), specifically Crohn’s disease and ulcerative colitis, in stable or moderately active phases.
3. Irritable Bowel Syndrome (IBS) requiring specialized dietary or pharmacologic intervention.
4. Screening, surveillance, and diagnostic evaluations for colorectal polyps.
5. Chronic viral hepatitis (Types B and C) without acute hepatic decompensation.

4.2.2 Explicitly Not Accepted Conditions

To maintain outpatient facility licensure and safety thresholds, the following conditions are excluded from all 14 Meridian Health Partners outpatient sites and must be redirected immediately to regional acute-care tertiary facilities:

1. Acute gastrointestinal hemorrhage requiring hemodynamic resuscitation or active blood transfusion.
2. Fulminant hepatic failure or acute-on-chronic liver failure exhibiting encephalopathy grade III or IV.
3. Acute abdominal emergencies, including suspected bowel perforation, acute pancreatitis, or toxic megacolon.
4. Pediatric gastroenterology cases involving patients under the age of 18 (refer to Meridian Pediatric Alliance).
5. Bariatric surgery evaluations and post-surgical bariatric revisions (refer to Meridian Metabolic Institute).

4.3 Appointment Durations

Scheduling templates for the Gastroenterology department must strictly adhere to the following slot allocations:

1. Initial New Patient Consultations: Allocated exactly 45 minutes per appointment.
2. Established Patient Follow-Up Visits: Allocated exactly 20 minutes per appointment.
3. Procedure Pre-Evaluation / Anesthesia Screening: Allocated exactly 30 minutes per appointment.

4.4 Patient Preparation Instructions

All clinical staff must issue the following standardized pre-procedure instructions based on the scheduled modality:
1. Upper Endoscopy (EGD): Patients must observe a strict nil per os (NPO) status, consuming no solid foods or clear liquids for a minimum of 8 hours prior to the scheduled procedure arrival time.
2. Lower Endoscopy (Colonoscopy): Patients must ingest the full prescribed polyethylene glycol electrolyte lavage solution split-dose regimen, consuming the first dose the evening before the procedure (starting precisely at 18:00) and the second dose 4 hours prior to the morning arrival time.
3. Medication Adjustments: Patients prescribed therapeutic anticoagulants or antiplatelet agents must receive clearance from prescribing cardiology or neurology specialists to withhold these agents 5 business days prior to any scheduled endoscopic procedure.

4.5 Insurance Coverage Matrix by Plan Tier

Meridian Health Partners operates four proprietary health plans. Coverage eligibility for outpatient gastroenterology procedures is delineated below:

Procedure Category	Meridian Choice Plan	Meridian Select Plan	Meridian Premier Plan	Meridian Value Plan
Diagnostic EGD	Covered (Subject to Tier 2 Copay)	Fully Covered	Fully Covered	Covered (Subject to Deductible)
Screening Colonoscopy	Fully Covered (100% Preventive)	Fully Covered (100% Preventive)	Fully Covered (100% Preventive)	Fully Covered (100% Preventive)
Diagnostic Colonoscopy	Covered (Subject to Deductible)	Fully Covered	Fully Covered	Not Covered (Out-of-Network Equivalent)
Capsule Endoscopy	Prior Authorization Required	Fully Covered	Fully Covered	Not Covered
FibroScan (Liver Elastography)	Covered (Specialist Referral Required)	Fully Covered	Fully Covered	Covered (Specialist Referral Required)

4.6 Referral Turnaround Commitment

4.6.1 Processing Timelines

The Gastroenterology department commits to a strict internal service level agreement (SLA) for all incoming provider-to-provider referrals:

1. Routine Referrals: All routine referrals received via the electronic health record must be triaged, reviewed by a licensed mid-level provider or gastroenterologist, and scheduled or declined within 3 business days of receipt.
2. Urgent Referrals: Referrals designated as urgent by the primary provider due to severe symptomology or rapid weight loss must be triaged and contacted for scheduling within 24 hours of receipt.

4.6.2 Named Exception

Referrals originating from outside the Meridian Health Partners integrated network that require external primary insurance authorization verification are exempt from the standard 3-business-day timeline. Such deferred cases shall be processed within a secondary window of 7 business days to allow for external payer administrative clearance.